



Bahla Fort

One of the finest examples of a medieval Islamic fortified oasis settlement

Bahla is one of four fortresses lying at the foot of the Jebel Akhdar highlands in Oman. Although evidence suggests that Bahla was settled and fortified from the first millennium BCE, the current fort was built by the Banu Nebhan tribe, which controlled much of Oman from the 12th to 15th centuries CE. The vast fort attests to the wealth of the Nebhani dynasty, accumulated through its dominance of the Middle Eastern trade in frankincense.

Bastion in the desert

Resting on sandstone foundations, 164ft (50m) above the oasis settlement that surrounds it, the fort is constructed in mud-brick. Inside the *Al-Qaabah* ("citadel"), there is a labyrinth of cells and chambers, with walls punctuated by openings through which boiling water or date juice could be poured on attackers. The outer walls, 8 miles (13km) long, enclose the entire oasis settlement, including the Friday Mosque, family compounds, audience halls, bath houses, and the remains of a semicovered market. After restoration, the fort was opened to the public in 2012.

▷ TYPICALLY OMANI

Bahla Fort's round towers and smooth walls, punctuated by small windows, are typical of the more than 500 forts, castles, and lookout towers found across Oman. Around 20 of these structures have been meticulously restored.

▷ OASIS CITADEL

The fort rises above the surrounding mud-brick settlement and palm grove of the oasis, which is irrigated by a system of wells and underground channels that bring water from distant springs.

Bahla was the **center** of the **Ibadi school of Islam**, founded 20 years after Prophet Muhammad's death

